

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ J 10 9 2
 ♥ 10 9 8
 ♦ 4
 ♣ A J 9 5 3

♠ A Q 5

♥ A K 7 5

♦ K Q 9 8 6 3

♣ —



♠ K 8 6
 ♥ Q 4 3 2
 ♦ 5
 ♣ K Q 10 4 2

♠ 7 4 3

♥ J 6

♦ A J 10 7 2

♣ 8 7 6

West	North	East	South
Pass	1♦	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	5♦
Pass	6♦		
All Pass			

6♦ by North

Lead: ♣K

North is to play 6♦. East leads the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 4

You don't really have 2 ♥ losers since both of them can be ruffed in dummy. The 2 ♠ losers are real, though, and must be dealt with. If West holds the ♠K then a simple finesse will win the contract for you. A 50% chance. But there is more to this Deal than a simple finesse, look at it carefully.

In addition to the trumps, dummy has another useful card, the ♥J. You can give yourself a second chance by playing East to hold the ♥Q.

You ruff the opening ♣ lead and pull trumps with the ♦K (they split 1-1).

A low ♥ toward the ♥J. East fidgets, then puts on the ♥Q and plays another ♣ which you ruff.

You are in control now. You play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J, then a ♠ back to your ♠A. Discard dummy's 2 ♠ losers on the ♥ A K and claim your slam.

Suppose that it was West who held the ♥Q. Your ♥J would have been taken and you wouldn't get the two ♠ discards.

Then you would have to rely on the ♠ finesse after all. You'd be no worse off because you could still discard one of dummy's ♠s on a big ♥.

This method of play gave you two chances instead of just one.

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K J 7
 ♥ K 7
 ♦ A J 10 8
 ♣ K J 9 6

♠ 6 4
 ♥ 10 9 5 4 2
 ♦ 7 6 4 2
 ♣ Q 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 9 8 2
 ♥ Q 6 3
 ♦ 9 5 3
 ♣ 8 4 3

♠ A Q 5 3
 ♥ A J 8
 ♦ K Q
 ♣ A 10 7 2

West	North	East	South
4♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
7NT		4NT	Pass
All Pass			
7NT by East			
Lead: ♠ 10			

East is to play 7NT. South leads the ♠ 10.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=2 Total = 12

A. Conan Doyle would have called this "The Tale of Two Queens". You need to find one more trick and to do so you are going to have to find either the ♥Q or the ♣Q. You can finesse North for the ♥Q, and you can finesse either defender for the ♣Q.

So which will you choose?

Neither, yet. First take your 8 winners in ♠s and ♦s, hoping somebody discards something to help you. They don't.

The ♣A, then the ♣K, hoping the ♣Q falls. If she does you have your thirteenth trick in ♣s. If she doesn't you take the ♥K then finesse North for the ♥Q. Two chances.

As you see, the ♥ finesse would have failed. You might have guessed the ♣Q correctly, but you might not have.

It always pays to look for a second chance. Here you try to drop the ♣Q, and if it doesn't work you have the finesse for the ♥Q in reserve.

Why not try to drop the ♥Q and keep the finesse for the ♣Q in reserve? Because you and dummy had 8 ♣s between you and only 6 ♥s. So the ♣Q was far more likely to be doubleton than the ♥Q.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A J 4
♥ Q 10 7 3
♦ 10 9 4
♣ 9 4 3

♠ Q 10 5

♥ 8 6 4

♦ A 7 5

♣ K Q 8 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 9 6 2

♥ J 9 5

♦ Q J 6 2

♣ 10 7

♠ 8 7 3

♥ A K 2

♦ K 8 3

♣ A J 5 2

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥3

West plays low.

East wins the ♠K.

East returns a ♥.

West follows and dummy plays the ♥6.

West plays the ♠J.

The ♠Q wins the trick. If the ♠Q wins, take your 9 tricks and run.

Although this doesn't look like a normal A Q finesse it really is about the same.

Whenever the ♠A and ♠K are in different hands, the only thing that matters is the location of the ♠J.

So it is basically a 50% chance.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥3, dummy plays the ♥4 and East the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

First things first. Win the first ♥, do not hold up. West's ♥3 indicates he has led a 4-card suit so a hold-up wouldn't help you. And if you did hold up they might pocket their ♥ trick and switch to ♦s, a suit you are no better off in.

You need to get one more winner and it will have to be a ♠ winner. You could lead toward the ♠Q, winning a trick if West holds BOTH the ♠A and ♠K. Or you could finesse the ♠10, gaining a trick if West holds the ♠J. Obviously the second choice is more likely.

Having won the first ♥ trick in your hand,

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 10 8
 ♥ K 4
 ♦ Q 5 3
 ♣ A K Q J

♠ 7
 ♥ Q 10 8 3
 ♦ K J 9 2
 ♣ 9 8 4 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q 9 6 2
 ♥ A 6 5
 ♦ 8 6 4
 ♣ 6 5 3

♠ K 5 4 3
 ♥ J 9 7 2
 ♦ A 10 7
 ♣ 10 7

West	North	East	South
2NT	Pass	3♣	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			
4♠ by West			
Lead: ♦ 2			

hand when South plays low.

The ♠Q held the trick so you are still in dummy.

South doesn't cover.

The ♠9, playing your ♠8 under it. North shows out on this trick and you are glad you played so carefully. Play one more ♠, finessing South's ♠K again, then play your ♠A and the rest of your winners.

If you had played the ♠Q and carelessly followed with the ♠8 on your first finesse you would have gone down. You would have had to win the second finesse in your hand and would have no dummy entry to let you take the third finesse.

True, the chances of South holding 4 ♠s to the King are pretty small, but it costs you nothing to protect yourself against that holding.

And the rewards are great.

West is to play 4♠. North leads the ♦2. The defenders win 3 ♦ tricks, then play a ♣.

Losers: ♠ = 0 or 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 3 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 or 4

Since you have already lost 3 ♦ tricks you cannot also lose a ♠ trick. That means South will have to have the ♠K and it also means that you will have to be careful with your finessing.

You are in your hand, having won the ♣ switch.

North plays low.

Over to dummy's ♥A.

South plays low.

The ♠Q from dummy, and the ♠J (or 10) from your

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 6 5 2
♥ A 9 6 2
♦ 10 8 3
♣ K 3

♠ A K 3

♥ K 4

♦ A K 6 5

♣ J 7 6 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 8 4

♥ Q J 8 7 3

♦ J 9 4

♣ 9 4

♠ Q 10 7

♥ 10 5

♦ Q 7 2

♣ A Q 10 8 5

West

North

East

South

1♦

Pass

2♣

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥7

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥7. West takes the ♥A and returns the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need one more winner and ♣s is your best suit. If the ♣K is in East's hand you can finesse it for 12 tricks. But if the ♣K is in West's hand you will lose that trick and at least 4 ♥s.

Before you put all your eggs in the ♣ finesse basket there is one thing you should do first.

You test the ♦ suit: a small one to dummy's ♦Q, then the ♦K and ♦A.

Both defenders followed three times, so your last ♦ is a winner.

You cash it.

Now you have a problem. You have won 5 tricks so far and you have 4 more winners ready to take. So you can take your 9 tricks and run, or you can finesse the ♣ trying for 3 overtricks.

It's your decision, but </br></br>

At Rubber Bridge or Team play it would probably be foolish to risk your contract for the sake of three overtricks.

But at Match Point Pairs the reward would be much greater, a probable very high board. Of course with this layout it might have gotten you a bottom board.